

to frosts, you may want to cover container-grown or wall-trained trees with horticultural fleece.

HARVESTING

Depending on the variety you grow, you may have apples ready to harvest as early as midsummer, but the timing of the harvest is crucial. If you harvest fruits too soon, you may keep them from developing their full flavor; too late and they may not store well. Ripe apples should pull away from the tree easily; do not rip them away or you could damage the spur. Be careful not to bruise the fruits as you remove and store them. Fruits will not all ripen at exactly the same time, and if you have varieties with different harvesting seasons, you may be able to pick for many months.

STORING

Generally, the later the season, the longer the apple will store. When apples are ripe, remove them gently from the tree and, spacing them so that they are not touching, lay them out on trays, or wrap them in tissue paper and hang in plastic bags. Store them in a cool, dark, place and check the fruits regularly for signs of decay.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Apples are prone to a range of diseases, including canker, scab, fire blight, and infectious rots. If any of these occur, increase the air flow through the tree's branches by pruning out the diseased wood. Spray with an appropriate fungicide.

Apples are prone to pests such as wasps, birds, winter moth caterpillars, aphids, and capsid bugs. Net to deter birds; set up a jam-trap to attract wasps; use grease bands on the tree and its stake to keep winter moth caterpillars from climbing the trunk and laying eggs in the tree; and if aphids or apple sawfly are detected, remove damaged fruits and spray trees with a pyrethroid insecticide. Resistance to pests and diseases can vary between cultivars, so check catalog for specific advice.



Capsid bugs (left) target young leaves, creating spots and ragged holes. **Wasps (right)** will target damaged fruits to feast on the sweet, ripe flesh.